

Privacy in the Age of Social Media

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Have you ever thought of how much you share on social media? What do you agree to when you accept a new functionality, share your location, camera, microphone, like or post? How often have you neglected the privacy policy when signing up on a new website? According to a 2018 Pew Research Center Survey, 91% of Americans believe they have lost control over how their personal data is collected and used by companies. Indeed, with the arrival of social media in our life it is difficult to keep record of what information about ourselves we share on the internet. In this article, we will see what exactly “Data Privacy” means, the impact of social media on it, and how to be aware of what you share online.

Data Privacy

Data Privacy refers to the protection of personal information that can uniquely identify an individual. These personal data include your IP address, your biometrics (everything that can be used to establish your identity such as your face or your fingertips), and many other things that you leave on the internet without realizing it and that could cause harm if not protected. This is where Data Privacy comes into play; online, it means that you are given the choice over how your information is collected, shared and used. In that regard, supporting data privacy means obtaining user consent before processing data, protecting it and offering control over it to their users. Many organizations have a legal obligation to respect data privacy rights under the laws like the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), as data privacy is necessary to protect each one of us in the vast world of the internet, and social media.

The Role of Social Media in Data Privacy

The control we hold on our information is limited. Almost every person that has a phone keeps it constantly on themselves; meaning that every option you agreed to (mic, camera, position...) continuously tracks and collects data. Moreover, with the growth of social media, it has become normal and usual to film in public areas, then to post. Thus, even if you take all precautions, you might get exposed on social media without any consent. And even more, with the emergence of AI, it is now very easy to take one's identity or information in order to create content. This has been seen with the fake Brad Pitt; a scammer successfully robbed 830 000€ from a French woman named Anne. Indeed, Anne was 53 and didn't know about the social media's dangers at that time, when she downloaded Instagram. Her ordeal began when “Brad Pitt” contacted her, and started to ask for money, saying that his bank accounts were frozen due to his divorce proceedings. Anne said later that "as someone who isn't very used to social media, I didn't really know what was happening to me", which led her to send money to the scammers, about 10 000€ each time. In the end, the scammer asked for about 800 000€ to pay for the fake Pitt's kidney cancer treatments, using AI-generated photos of Brad Pitt in a hospital bed, which Anne couldn't see through. Because of this, Anne lost all of her savings and tried to take her life 3 times, also due to the wave of harassment she went through because of thousands of social media users mocking her.

The Impact It Has on Us

You must have heard about the saying “nothing ever gets deleted from the internet”, well it is most of the time true. Everything we post and do is archived in servers and databases, and even if really hard to find, all information is consigned and could be found. And, as we give more and more personal information to social media companies, we must know to what extent they might stock and use them. This might be seen through the 2018 Facebook accident where a data breach exposed the personal information of over 50 million users, leading to compromised users’ privacy but also identity theft, financial fraud, and other serious consequences. That data may also be a path to facilitate government surveillance as they rely progressively more on social media to monitor citizens, track political activities etc... This is the mechanism the USA uses when foreigners demand a VISA; they will go through your social media accounts before handing you a VISA. And finally, that data may be used as a tool for capitalism. Indeed, Meta now uses a data-driven economy; from its debut, Facebook was designed to collect vast amounts of user information such as every like, share, comment, and message. This personal data is then used to create detailed user profiles which are sold to advertisers for targeted marketing.

How to Protect Ourselves

The main thing to know is that you probably agreed to everything that happens to your personal data; hence the privacy policies you accept each time you sign up on a website or app, but without truly reading and acknowledging them. Thus the first thing to do to reclaim the control over your personal information is to understand what you are agreeing to when you use your phone, let access to your camera, location, or microphone. Empowerment through knowledge and awareness is the key to prevent a wrong use of your data. You might also want to protect your data and accounts by activating the 2 factor authentication, renouncing or restricting permissions when logging on a website, and not accepting everything the website asks you to, like cookies. More broadly, you can simply start by paying attention to what you post online; don’t give complete information about yourself, use a pseudonym, don’t tell where you live, don’t get personal, secure your accounts with strong passwords, review your privacy settings...

Conclusion

Data privacy is complicated, and so are the solutions to keep it strong. Through this article we were able to understand what data privacy is, how heavily important it is in social media, the impact it has on us when endangered, and finally how to protect it. Indeed, the information we show online constitutes our digital identity, and a path to our real-life self. Thus, data privacy is critical when it comes to social media and the internet in general; hold onto it carefully and keep track of what information you share online, because in the end, your data is your identity, so protect it like you would protect yourself.

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